

Chapter 22

Focus and the association with focus sensitive particle *yerane* in Kasem

Daniel Aremu

Goethe-Universität Frankfurt

This paper investigates the syntax of focus and the focus sensitive particle *yerane* ‘only’ in Kasem (Mabia, formerly Gur). I begin by discussing focus realization in Kasem, and sketched an analysis for it. Next, I discuss the syntactic position of the exclusive particle *yerane* by comparing it with the German’s *nur*, and argue that unlike German’s Extended Verbal Projection (EVP) claim by Buring & Hartmann (2001), Kasem’s *yerane* is adnominal in nature.¹ However, I show that Buring & Hartmann’s (2001) EVP analysis for *nur* may be extended to Kasem, but with an important additional assumption: that *yerane* is licensed by a high covert exclusive operator (Op_{only}) which occupies an EVP position, and is responsible for the exclusive semantics. Thus, following earlier studies, I assume that this is a bipartite analysis which requires that the exclusive interpretation comes from the high exclusive operator [Op] instead of the adnominal-*yerane* itself (see Bayer 1996, 1999, 2018, Lee 2004, Barbiers 2010, Quek & Hirsch 2017, Sun 2021, Branam & Erlewine 2023: a.o.). In order to link the high exclusive Op with the adnominal-*yerane*, I assume a purely syntactic agreement system.

1 Introduction

Because of their significance to the study and understanding of focus system and realization, focus-sensitive particles have received considerable attention,

¹The term *adnominal* is used interchangeably with *adfocal* in this paper. However, the latter is used in a more wholistic way, i.e. when discussing adjunction to both nominals and non-nominals.



cross-linguistically. However, most of these studies are geared towards Indo-European languages such as English, Dutch, German, French, Greek, and so on (cf. Rooth 1985, 1992, Bayer 1996, 1999, Kayne 1998, Barbiers 2010, 2014, Iatridou & Tatevosov 2016, Quek & Hirsch 2017). Some non-Indo-European languages that have equally received some amount of attention include Mandarin Chinese, Vietnamese, Japanese, and so on (cf. Lee 2004, Hole 2017, Erlewine 2014a,b, Erlewine & Kotek 2018, Sun 2021). African languages have received very little attention with regard to the nature of the focus-sensitive particles like *even*, *also* and *only*. See for instance, Hartmann & Zimmermann (2008), Grubic (2015) and Carstens & Zeller (2020) for studies on Bura, Ngamo and Nguni respectively. When it comes to the syntax of focus sensitive particles, African languages, or at least West African languages present interesting questions. This is partly because of the kinds of focus strategies that these groups of languages employ. For instance, while languages like English and German mark focus prosodically, most West African languages primarily mark focus morphosyntactically. There is usually a dedicated morphological focus marker that is present when an element is focalized. A focus constituent can also be fronted to the left periphery for interpretive purposes (É. Kiss 1998, Cruschina 2009, 2012, Bianchi et al. 2016). These different strategies and different focus positions leave us with questions such as what is/are the syntactic position(s) of focus sensitive particles like *even*, *also* and *only*?² Does the syntactic position of the focus sensitive particles suffice for the syntactic requirement of association with focus? This study aims to answer these questions by focusing on the exclusive focus sensitive particle (FSP) *yerane* ‘only’ in Kasem.

Let us begin with focus, which is the foundation for AwF. Consider the sentences below. The interrogative sentence in (1a) has a *wh*-phrase whose answer is a focused constituent in (1b).³ The focus indicates the presence of other contextually determined set of alternatives such as [bread, avocado, banana, fries, ...]. In other words, John could have eaten something else apart from a SANDWICH.

- (1) a. What did John eat?
- b. John ate A SANDWICH.

If we add an FSP like *only* to the focus answer as in (2b), we get the assertion and the truth condition in (3). The presence of the FSP *only* does not change

²Beaver & Clark (2008) categorizes these three FSPs as *Conventional Association Particles* because, according to them, they require the presence of a focus constituent in their scope. (cf. Erlewine 2014b: a.o.)

³Small caps is used to represent the constituents that are focused in the English translation.

the assertion of the focus sentence. It however affects the truth condition of the sentence: the sentence is true iff John ate a sandwich and nothing else. FSPs act upon the salient alternatives that the focus evokes. What happens with *only* as an exclusive particle is that it excludes all other salient alternatives except the focus constituent.⁴

- (2) a. Did John eat a sandwich and a banana?
b. John ate *only* a SANDWICH.
- (3) a. Asserts: John ate a sandwich
b. Entails: John ate nothing else (apart from a sandwich)

Kasem is a Mabilia (formerly Gur) language that is spoken predominantly in Northern Ghana, Burkina Faso, and Togo. It is an SVO language with noun classes. Interaction between the noun classes and number is reflected on the choice of the determiner (see Awedoba 1996). The sentence in (4b) shows a canonical word order in Kasem. The canonical word order structure is represented in (5); showing the post-verbal position of the internal argument and the pre-verbal position of the external argument respectively. The T head can be filled with past tense morphemes. When the aspect is imperfective, it is morphologically realized as a suffix to the verb as *-id* as in (4b). However, in perfective clauses, there is no overt morpheme. The left periphery of the clause (between ForceP and TP) houses the informational structural phrases like TopP and FocP, hence the three dots [...] in the structure in (5).

- (4) a. Tell me something (that I need to know).
b. Adam pa'a kɔdig-id nua.
Adam IMM.PST slaughter-IPFV fowl
'Adam was slaughtering a fowl.'

⁴The other conventional association particles (additive *also* and scalar additive *even*) do not affect the truth-condition of the proposition as in (i). They however presuppose that apart from the focus constituent (sandwich), there is at least one other alternative that is contextually relevant that John ate. The only difference between the two has to do with scalarity. While *also* is non-scalar (i.a), *even* is a scalar particle (i.b). For example, in (i.b), the presence of *even* presupposes that the focus associate is ranked high on the scale of what John is likely not going to eat (in comparison to other salient alternative(s)). In other words, while the focus associate is high on the relevant scale, the alternatives are ranked low. Thus, the lower we go on the relevant scale, the more likely the alternatives become (see a.o., König 1991, Jacobs 1983, Beaver & Clark 2008, Hole 2017).

- (i) a. John also ate a SANDWICH .
b. John even ate *only* a SANDWICH.

- (5) [_{ForceP} ... [_{TP} DP_{EA} [_{T'} T [_{AspP} V+v+Asp [_{VP} ⟨DP_{EA}⟩ [_{v'} ⟨V+v⟩] [_{VP} ⟨V⟩ DP_{IA}]]]]]]]]

Lastly, there are a few linguistic studies on Kasem, which makes it a “fertile ground” for linguistic research. See Awedoba (1996) and some of the references therein for a list of studies on Kasem. See also Bodomo (2020) and the other studies in that collection for a survey of Mabia languages in general.

Having given a brief introduction to focus, AwF, and the syntax of the language, the remaining part of this paper is based on the following sections. Section 2 begins with a description of focus realization in Kasem, and then an analysis would be proposed which sets the stage for AwF. In Section 3, I discuss the syntactic property of *yerane* and show that it indeed has an *adnominal* realization. A bipartite analysis with agreement between a high exclusive Op and *yerane* is provided in Section 4. Lastly, a summary and areas for further research are presented in Section 5.

2 Focus realization

2.1 Focus marking strategy

In Kasem, a constituent is marked as focused with the use of a morphological focus marker *mo*. *Mo* forms a constituent with the focus DP, PP, VP and adjunct. All these focus constituents can be realized either in their canonical position (in-situ) or at the left periphery of the clause (ex-situ). For instance, when an object *wh*-question like (6a) is asked, the answer can be in the form of the sentence in (6b) where the focus answer remains in its canonical position followed by *mo*, or it can be fronted to the left periphery as in (6c). The latter case also has *mo* following the focus constituent.⁵

- (6) a. Bε ***(mo)** Adam go-a?
 what FOC Adam slaughter-DISJ
 ‘What did Adam slaughter?’
 b. Adam go [chworō]_F ***(mo)**.
 Adam slaughter fowl FOC
 ‘Adam slaughtered A FOWL.’
 c. [Chworō]_F ***(mo)** Adam go-a.
 fowl FOC Adam slaughter-DISJ
 ‘Adam slaughtered A FOWL.’

⁵I will use the square bracket plus F-marking [XP]_F to distinguish the focus constituent from the background. The focus marker **mo** will be in bold and it is obligatory.

The same strategy is used with regard to adjunct focus. The adverbial focus answer is followed by *mo*. The resulting constituent can be in an in-situ position (7b) or an ex-situ position (7c), respectively.

- (7) a. Maŋ-k̄s **mo** Adam go chworo kom?
time-which FOC Adam slaughter fowl DEF
‘When did Adam slaughter the fowl?’
b. Adam go chworo kom [diim]_F **mo**.
Adam slaughter fowl DEF yesterday FOC
‘Adam slaughtered the fowl YESTERDAY.’
c. [Diim]_F **mo** Adam go chworo kom.
yesterday FOC Adam slaughter fowl DEF
‘Adam slaughtered the fowl YESTERDAY.’

With respect to V(P) focus, the focus marker *mo* immediately follows the verb if it is an intransitive verb (8b), i.e. without any internal argument. However, if the verb is transitive, *mo* follows the direct object instead (8c). The consequence of this is ambiguity. The focus could be on the verb itself, the whole verb phrase, or even the direct object. The only way to distinguish between what seems to be ambiguous on the surface is through the current question that the structure answers.

- (8) a. Bε **mo** Adam kea dīim?
what FOC Adam do yesterday
‘What did Adam do yesterday?’
b. Adam [toŋe]_F **mo** dīim.
Adam worked FOC yesterday
‘Adam WORKED yesterday.’
c. Adam [go chworo kom]_F **mo** dīim.
Adam slaughter fowl DEF FOC yesterday
‘Adam SLAUGHTERED THE FOWL yesterday.’

The verb and/or verb phrase cannot be fronted in Kasem, whether the verb is doubled (9b) or not (9c). They remain in their external merged position when they are focused.⁶

⁶This is unlike other Mabilia languages like Kusaal and Likpakpaanl that have verb focus fronting only if the fronted verb is nominalized and have an overt copy in its base position.

- (9) a. Be mo Adam kea?
 what FOC Adam do
 ‘What did Adam do?’
 b. *[Tone]_F mo Adam tone.
 worked FOC Adam work
 ‘Adam WORKED.’
 c. *[Tone]_F mo Adam t .
 worked FOC Adam
 ‘Adam WORKED.’

2.2 Focus analysis

For the focus analysis, I assume that *mo* forms a constituent with the focus phrase. Consider the sentences below. They show the different possible placement of *mo* in the clause; it obligatorily follows whatever is the focus constituent. *Mo* follows the direct object in (10a), the indirect object in (10b), and the adverb in (10c). On the first glance, these examples suggest that *mo* forms a constituent with the focus. As a reviewer pointed out, the post-focal position of *mo* can still be derived via various movements in examples (10a) and (10b). For instance, assuming that *mo* is the head of a VP-internal FocP and the focused DP moves to Spec,FocP, we could derive (10b) by assuming that the direct object moves to a position higher than FocP.

- (10) a. Adam pe [sabu kom]_F mo John diim.
 Adam give money DEF FOC John yesterday
 ‘Adam gave THE MONEY to John yesterday.’
 b. Adam pe sabu kom [John]_F mo diim.
 Adam give money DEF John FOC yesterday
 ‘Adam gave JOHN the money yesterday.’
 c. Adam pe sabu kom John [diim]_F mo.
 Adam give money DEF John yesterday FOC
 ‘Adam gave John the money YESTERDAY.’

While this is a plausible analysis, the challenge with such an analysis would be to determine the position that the direct object moves to. We would need to assume probably an FP to accommodate the direct object in order to derive the linear order. Such movements would be unmotivated.

Perhaps, example (10c) offers a better evidence for the constituent status of *mo*. Here, we have a case of adverbial focus with *mo* following it. Again, if we wish to derive such a structure by assuming a VP-internal FocP, then we would need two positions to move both the direct object and the indirect object into.

Ex-situ focus offers convincing evidence for our constituency claim here. The fact that each of the focus phrases that are in-situ in (10) can be fronted, as in (11), with an obligatory *mo* following them supports the view that both *mo* and focus phrases form a constituent.

- (11) a. [Sabu kom]_F **mo** Adam pɛ John diim.
 money DEF FOC Adam give John yesterday
 ‘Adam gave THE MONEY to John yesterday.’
 b. [John]_F **mo** Adam pɛ sabu kom diim.
 John FOC Adam give money DEF yesterday
 ‘Adam gave JOHN the money yesterday.’
 c. [Diim]_F **mo** Adam pɛ sabu kom John.
 yesterday FOC Adam give money DEF John
 ‘Adam gave John the money YESTERDAY.’

In order to derive the in-situ focus structure, I use the focus answer in (12b) as a template. The assumption is that *mo* adjoins to the focus DP and then projects a functional phrase called *moP* (Figure 1).⁷ Nothing hinges on the name of this projection. It can as well be called a DP. It is within the nominal domain, and the features on the focus DP are present at *moP*.

- (12) a. Bɛ *(**mo**) Adam go-a?
 what FOC Adam slaughter-DISJ
 ‘What did Adam slaughter?’
 b. Adam go [chworɔ]_F *(**mo**).
 Adam slaughter fowl FOC
 ‘Adam slaughtered A FOWL.’

Next, the structure is built up to the TP level. Then, a FocP is projected in the left periphery (Figure 2). The head of the FocP is null but has an interpretable unvalued feature. It is interpretable because it licenses the focus phrase and is responsible for the focus semantics. *Mo* is more or less the exponent for the

⁷The number [3] is only an index notation that represent feature valuation. We can as well use *val* (which equally stand for a valued feature), à la Pesetsky & Torrego (2007).

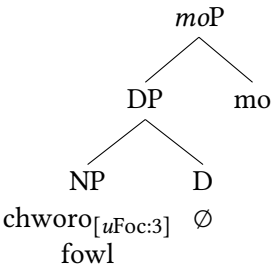


Figure 1: *Mo*-adjunction

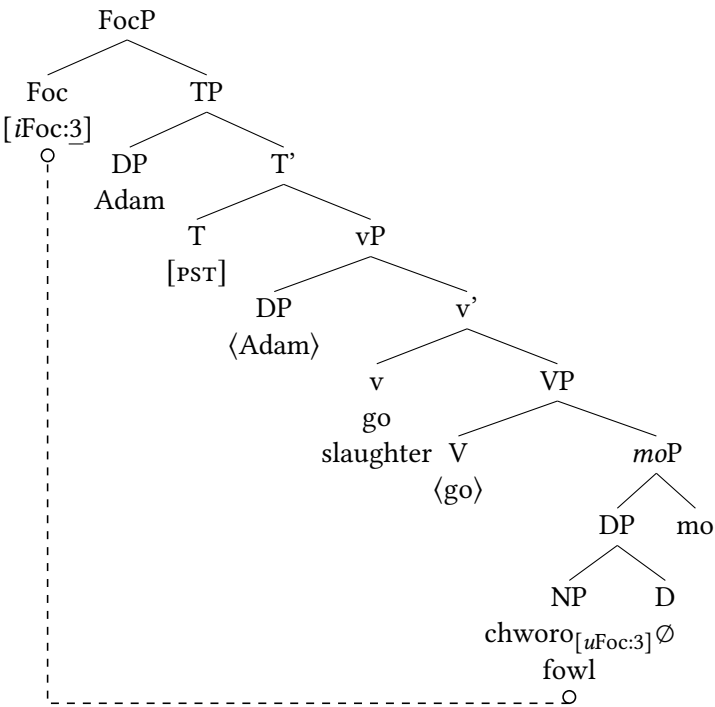


Figure 2: In-situ focus structure

valued feature on the focus DP. The unvalued feature on the focus head probes for valuation. Foc finds the focus DP which has a valued feature, and then Agrees with it. This results in a shared feature value [3].⁸ I assume that in in-situ focus, Foc lacks an EPP. So, only agreement took place. The focus does not move to Spec,FocP, at least overtly.

A reviewer wonders how an unvalued feature can be interpretable. This may only seem to be an odd assumption based on Chomsky's (2000, 2001) initial view of Agree (specifically in the Minimalist Inquiries/Derivation by Phase framework) which is summed up with the *biconditional* statement below.⁹ Based on (13), the prediction is that an uninterpretable feature cannot be valued, and an interpretable feature cannot be unvalued.

(13) **Biconditional of Valuation & Interpretability** (Chomsky 2001: 5)

A feature F is uninterpretable iff F is unvalued.

However, subsequent work (beginning notably with Pesetsky & Torrego (2007)) has argued for the possibility of an interpretable but unvalued feature by eliminating the biconditional view of Chomsky. Pesetsky & Torrego's types of feature combination is giving below. The types in boldface are the novel types they added, and only the two types in the lower line can act as probes. In short, only unvalued features act as probes. Therefore, the assumption in this paper falls exactly within the purview of Pesetsky & Torrego's view of Agree (also Chomsky's based on unvalued feature = probe).¹⁰

(14) **Pesetsky & Torrego's (2007) types of features**

<i>uF val</i> uninterpretable, valued	<i>iF val</i> interpretable, valued
<i>uF</i> [] uninterpretable, unvalued	<i>iF</i> [] interpretable, unvalued

For the ex-situ focus strategy, the head of the left peripheral FocP is specified with an EPP feature which requires the fronting of the focus constituent. Consider the repeated ex-situ example below.

- (15) [Chworo]_F ^{*}(**mo**) Adam go-a.
 fowl FOC Adam slaughter-DISJ
 'Adam slaughtered A FOWL.'

⁸Notice that the valuation index [3] is underlined. This is after valuation has taken place. Before valuation, it looks like this: [*i*Foc:].

⁹MI = Minimalist Inquiry; DbP = Derivation by Phase

¹⁰See Pesetsky & Torrego (2007), and the references they cited, for empirical evidence supporting such a wider view of Agree possibilities.

The structure is given in Figure 3. The head of FocP is still covert but has both an unvalued focus feature and an EPP. The unvalued focus feature causes the head to probe downward and Agrees with the goal (object focus). Next, the whole of *moP* moves to Spec,FocP in the left periphery. So, agreement feeds movement.

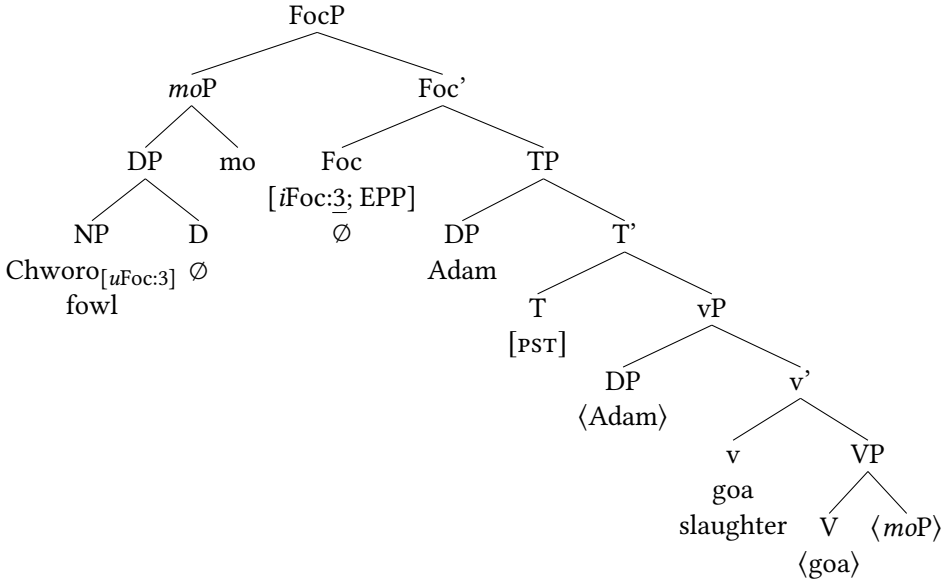


Figure 3: Agreement and focus fronting

So far, I have discussed the focus construction in Kasem and provided an analysis for it. The stage is now set for the next section which concerns the association with focus, with the exclusive focus-sensitive particle *yerane* ('only') as the case study.

3 FSP *yerane* and the association with focus

3.1 *Yerane* associating with focus

The exclusive focus-sensitive particle *yerane* and its focus associate are contiguous. *Yerane* follows the focus associate but precedes the focus marker *mo*. This position is constant regardless of whether the associate is a subject, an object,

or an adjunct.¹¹ With a context like (16a), the answer involves a subject focus (16b) with the exclusive *yerane* occurring between the subject focus and *mo*.¹² The presence of the focus marker is obligatory in all cases.

- (16) a. Wɔ mo toje? Adam *(mo) naa John *(mo)?
 who FOC work.PFV Adam FOC DISJ John FOC
 ‘Who worked: Adam or John?’
 b. [Adam]_F **yerane mo** toje.
 Adam only FOC work.PFV
 ‘Only ADAM worked.’

Association with an object focus has the same structure of [associate < *yerane* < *mo*]. This structure is retained when the focus associate is in a post-verbal position (17a) or when it is fronted (17b). The same thing applies to association with adjunct focus as in (18). This leads to the proposal that *yerane* further forms a complex constituent with the local FocP that was derived in Section 2. I will come back to this soon.

- (17) a. Adam go [chworɔ]_F **yerane *(mo)**.
 Adam kill.PFV fowl only FOC
 ‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’
 b. [Chworɔ]_F **yerane *(mo)** Adam go-a.
 fowl only FOC Adam kill.PFV-DISJ
 ‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’
 (18) a. Adam toje [diim]_F **yerane *(mo)**.
 Adam work.PFV yesterday only FOC
 ‘Adam only worked YESTERDAY.’

¹¹The focus categories that show a different distribution of *yerane* are VP and TP. For instance, when the focus is on a transitive verb, both *yerane* and *mo* follow the direct object, and not the verb (i.b).

- (i) a. Adam yeigi lɔɔre dem mo naa o kwei lɔɔre dem o yeigi mo.
 Adam buy car DEF FOC DISJ 3SG pick car DEF 3SG sell FOC
 ‘Did Adam **buy** the car or **sell** the car?’
 b. Aawo, O [yeigi]_F lɔɔre dem **yerane mo**.
 no 3SG buy car DEF only FOC
 ‘No, he only **BOUGHT** the car.’

¹²Just like the focus marker, I will use a boldface for the exclusive particle *yerane*.

- b. $[[\text{Diim}]_F \text{ yerane } ^*(\text{mo})]_i$ Adam torje _____j.
 yesterday only FOC Adam work.PFV
 ‘Adam only worked YESTERDAY.’

3.2 Is *yerane* adnominal, adverbial or both?

Based on the structural position of the exclusive particle *only* in the clause, there are two groups of linguists who posit that *only* can either have an *adverbial* property (Jacobs 1983, 1986, Büring & Hartmann 2001) or a *mixed* property (Bayer 1996, 1999, 2018, Reis 2005, Barbiers 2014, Smeets & Wagner 2018). In other words, while the former involves *only* adjoining to an Extended Verbal Projection (henceforth EVP), the latter involves both an adverbial (EVP) and an adnominal adjunction of *only*. In German, for instance, Büring & Hartmann (2001) have argued that *nur* ‘only’ adjoins to the EVPs regardless of whether the focus is a DP argument or a non-DP argument (VP, TP, CP) (19) (see also Mursell 2021).

- (19) Ich habe [_{VP} **nur** [_{VP} [_{DP} einen Roman]_F gelesen]]
 I have only a novel read
 'I have only read A NOVEL.' (Büring & Hartmann 2001: 231)

Due to the V2 property of German, the auxiliary verb *haben* occupies the V2 position, and causes the main verb *gelesen* to be in a sentence-final position. This makes it look as though *nur* is adnominal on the surface in the example above.¹³ However, according to Buring & Hartmann 2001: 233 if *nur* adjoins to a DP complement of a preposition (20) or inside a complex DP (21), the constructions are ungrammatical. The reasoning behind this is that these constructions should be fine if *nur* is adnominal.

- (20) a. *mit **nur** Hans
with only Hans
'with only Hans'
b. *[PP P FP DP]
- (21) a. *der Bruder **nur** des Grafen
the brother only the-GEN count-GEN
'the brother of only the count'
b. *[DP D FP DP]

¹³This view of *nur* in German is not without its own challenges. In fact, there are others who have argued that German rather involves a mixed-analysis- adverbial and adnominal (see Reis 2005, Meyer & Sauerland 2009, Bayer 1996, 2018, Hole 2015, Smeets & Wagner 2018: among others). I will not go through their interesting arguments here.

In contrast, English, for example, uses the mixed-analysis where *only* can either adjoin to the focus associate itself (22a) or an EVP (22b) (König 1991, Erlewine 2014b).¹⁴

- (22) a. John ate **only** [rice]_F.
 b. John **only** ate [rice]_F.

Kasem's *yerane* is strictly adnominal with regard to its position. If we adjoin *yerane* to the DP complement of a preposition (as done for German above), the result is a grammatical structure (23b).

- (23) a. Adam di wodiu kom de dúrú de seo diim na?
 Adam eat.PFV food DEF with spoon CONJ knife yesterday Q
 'Did Adam eat the food with a spoon and a knife yesterday?'
 b. Aawo, o di wodiu kom [pp de [dúró]_F yerane mo]
 no 3SG eat.PFV food DEF with spoon only FOC
 diim.
 yesterday.
 'No, he only ate the food with A SPOON yesterday.'

However, this does not tell us much because of the position of *yerane* and *mo*: they seem to be in the clause-final position. It could be argued that they adjoin to an EVP. This is unlike English and German where *only* and *nur* precedes the focus DP but follows the preposition. Nevertheless, there is other evidence that supports the adnominal nature of *yerane*. First is the fact that the same complex constituent that we find in the postverbal (in-situ) position is also present in the left periphery of the clause (24).

- (24) [[Chworo]_F yerane mo] Adam go-a.
 fowl only FOC Adam kill.PFV-DISJ
 'Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.'

Secondly, the focus associate cannot be fronted leaving *yerane* stranded (25).¹⁵

¹⁴See also König (1991) on Bengali.

¹⁵A reviewer highlighted an important point that needs to be addressed here. In English, where *only* can adjoin to the EVP, if a constituent is moved out of *only*'s c-command domain (as in i), this would only mean that association between *only* and the dislocated element is lost (see Erlewine 2014a,b on why there is a lack of backward association with *only* in English). However, *only* can still associate with the verb or even the indirect object. But the same is not true for Kasem because *yerane* is adnominal in (25). Once its focus associate is fronted, stranding *yerane* does not result in association with the verb go 'to kill' in (25).

- (i) A new bicycle John **only** loaned to Mary.

- (25) *[Chworo]_F **mo** Adam go **yerane**.
 fowl FOC Adam kill.PFV only
 ‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’

In contrast, the focus associate can move to the ‘prefield’ position in German, leaving *nur* behind. This should not be possible if both form a constituent. Consider the German sentence from Mursell 2021: 196 (citing Jacobs 1983: 43) below.¹⁶

- (26) Der MENSCH interessiert ihn **nur**, (nicht die Arbeit).
 the human interest.3SG him only not the work
 ‘Only the HUMAN interests him, not the work.’

Finally, there is indirect evidence from the language with regard to the behaviour of another FSP *mane* ‘even’.¹⁷ The additive scalar particle *mane* behaves like an adverbial-*even* in English because it does not form a constituent with the focus associate (27b). In fact, it allows the focus associate to move to the left periphery of the clause while it remains in its pre-verbal position (27c) (see Erlewine (2014a) and the references therein for the arguments on why backward association with *even* is possible in English). It does not move to the left periphery with the focus associate (27d). It behaves more like the German *nur* case, and not like *yerane*.¹⁸

- (27) a. Napog ne vara dede diim.
 Napog see.PFV animal many yesterday
 ‘Napog saw many animals yesterday.’

¹⁶ Again, the whole picture is not as simple as it seems. Several studies have argued for the presence of ad-focal *nur* in German (see Reis 2005, Meyer & Sauerland 2009, Hole 2015: a.o.). But for the sake of our analysis here, I follow Buring & Hartmann (2001) to assume an adverbial *nur*.

¹⁷ In the presence of the additive scalar particle *mane*, the focus marker *mo* is optional when the focus associate is in an in-situ position, but obligatory when the focus associate is fronted. Compare the examples (27b) and (27c).

¹⁸ An interesting phenomenon is observed in association with *mane* ‘even’, which is the presence of a lower copy subject pronoun. Why this is so is unclear at this point. A reviewer asked whether *mane* could be an auxiliary. This is a possibility because modal auxiliaries in the language have similar structures. For example, the sentence in (i) with the modal *wae* ‘may’ involves a pronoun which resumes the subject. This is an interesting phenomenon which I leave for a future research.

- (i) Adam wae *(o) go chworo.
 Adam may 3SG kill.PFV fowl
 ‘Adam may slaughter a fowl.’

- b. O **maje** o na [teiri]_F.
 3SG even 3SG see pig
 ‘He even saw A PIG.’
- c. [[Teiri]_F ***(mo)**]_i o **maje** o na _____j.
 pig FOC 3SG even 3SG see
 ‘He even saw A PIG.’
- d. ***[[Teiri]_F **maje** ***(mo)**]_i o ____ o na _____j.
 pig even FOC 3SG 3SG see
 ‘He even saw A PIG.’**

So far, I have shown that the exclusive particle *yerane* is adnominal in Kasem. Next is the proposed analysis.

4 Proposed analysis

In this section, I will propose a syntactic analysis for *yerane*. I will show that Büring & Hartmann’s (2001) EVP proposal may still be extended to Kasem. The only thing is that we need to assume that *yerane* is an ad-focal (embeds the adnominal property) operator whose semantics depends on a covert exclusive operator (Op_{only}) which can occupy the EVP positions proposed by Büring & Hartmann (2001).¹⁹ I will begin by showing that this idea is technically a bipartite or concord analysis which is similar to the negative concord analysis (cf. Zeijlstra 2004: a.o.), and has also received cross-linguistic considerations (Quek & Hirsch 2017, Sun 2021, Branen & Erlewine 2023: a.o.).

4.1 Introducing the bipartite analysis

Considering languages like English that have a mixed-analysis for *only* viz: *adverbial-only* and *adnominal-only*, it has been argued that there is a higher position for *only* in the form of an exclusive operator (henceforth Op_{only}) that could be (c)overt. This is similar to what has been proposed for negation for example, where a higher Neg Op Agrees with a lower Neg(s) in languages with negative concord and/or negative indefinites (see a.o., Zeijlstra 2004, 2008, 2011, Penka 2011). This is a case of doubling. In the case of *only*-doubling, it is argued that the

¹⁹In fact, this is also the position of Hole (2015) for German. Hole (2015) argues that the German *nur* have instances of both adverbial (v-level, in his words) exclusives and ad-focal exclusives where either of them can be covert depending on a rule he called *First Come, First Spell-Out*. See particularly Hole (2015) section 3.3, for nice arguments.

complex constituent of the *adnominal*-only plus its focus associate raises to the Spec of a higher Op_{only} which is seen as a scope position. This movement could either be *covert* or *overt* as shown in Figure 4 (cf. Bayer 1996, 1999, Kayne 1998, Erlewine & Kotek 2018, Sun 2021). Thus, the exclusive interpretation actually comes from the Op_{only} , and the *adnominal*-only is only a semantically vacuous concord marker.

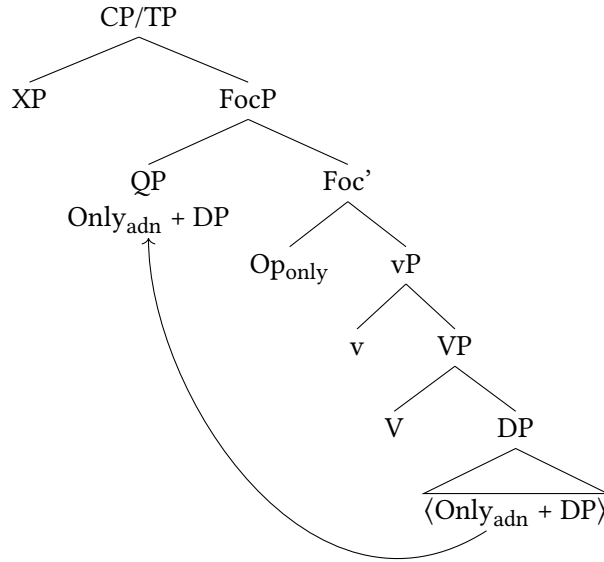


Figure 4: (C)overt raising of *adnominal*-only + DP

Another approach that has been proposed for the bipartite analysis is (28). Under this approach, the *adnominal*-only enters into the syntax with an uninterpretable exclusive feature [*uExcl*], and Agrees with the Op_{only} which has an interpretable exclusive feature [*iExcl*]. The agreement occurs under a Spec-Head relationship (28) (Sun 2021, Hole 2017, Quek & Hirsch 2017, Yip 2025). The advantage of these approaches is the provision of a unified analysis in which ‘only’, as a propositional operator, is really adverbial and is interpreted in an EVP position in the sense of Büring & Hartmann (2001). The adfocal particles are more or less concord-like elements.

- (28) [CP/TP [FocP [QP only_[uExcl] + DP]_i [Op_[iExcl] [vP ... t_i]]]]

One argument for these approaches is the ability of the *adnominal*-only to realize an ambiguous scope reading in the presence of modals (cf. Taglicht 1984, Bayer 1999, Quek & Hirsch 2017). Although, on the surface, the position of the *adnominal*-only is lower in the clause, it can scope not only below the modal, but also above it. The sentence in (29) can have the two readings in (30), depending on the scope of *only*.

(29) John *may* slaughter *only* A HEN. [only > may; may > only]

(30) a. [may > only]:

John is allowed to not slaughter any animal other than a hen.

b. [only > may]:

John is not allowed to slaughter any animal other than a hen.

Not only modals, but also other quantificational elements like negation and quantificational adverbs can trigger a ambiguous scope reading for *adnominal*-only. With this in mind, it therefore seems that there is a null Op in the clausal spine that accommodates the observed ambiguity. This has been observed in other languages such as Vietnamese, Mandarin, Cantonese, German, and Dutch (see a.o., Bayer 1996, 1999, Lee 2004, Barbiers 2010, 2014, Hole 2017, Sun 2021, Yip 2025).

4.2 Extending the bipartite analysis to Kasem

The bipartite analysis can be extended to the Kasem AwF case. The *adnominal-yerane* can have an ambiguous scope reading. First, I will discuss the ambiguous scope reading in relation to *adnominal-yerane* with a modal and a higher predicate. Secondly, I will adopt a downward Agree system to the bipartite analysis (and not Spec-head Agree), as this will account for the post-verbal AwF context.

4.2.1 *Adnominal-yerane* with modals

In (31), the presence of the modal auxiliary *wae* ‘may/can’ creates an environment for the ambiguous scope reading. The exclusive particle could either scope above or below the modal verb (32). This supports the claim for the presence of an empty exclusive *Op* in a higher position, which means that it is not a *what you see is what you get* case. The ambiguous scope suggests that the exclusive interpretation comes from a higher position instead of the *adnominal* position of *yerane*.²⁰

²⁰It is important to point out here that the ambiguous scope property of *yerane* may also be analyzed with a quantifier-raising approach, instead of a bipartite agreement analysis that is

- (31) [only > may; may > only]
Adam wae *(o) go [chworō]_F yerane *(mo).
Adam may 3SG kill.PFV fowl only FOC
‘Adam may slaughter only A FOWL.’
- (32) a. [may > only]:
Adam is allowed to not slaughter any animal other than a fowl.
b. [only > may]:
Adam is not allowed to slaughter any animal other than a fowl.

4.2.2 Adnominal-*yerane* with higher predicates

The ambiguous scope is also realized when an adnominal-*yerane* occurs within the infinite CP complement of a higher predicate like *require* (à la Taglicht 1984). In the data in (33), *yerane* adjoins to the object of the embedded non-finite verb. The two possible readings that are derived are given in (34).

- (33) [only > require; require > only]
Adam jege se o di [mumuna]_F yerane mo.
Adam require to 3SG eat rice only FOC
‘Adam is required to eat only RICE.’
- (34) a. [only > require]:
The only requirement is that Adam eat rice (no other requirement).
b. [require > only]:
The requirement is for Adam to eat only rice.

4.2.3 Agreement

I will now propose an agreement system for my analysis. The agreement mechanism provides the possibility of linking different syntactic positions for interpretive reasons. Usually, these positions carry identical feature(s) which can be *interpretable* or *uninterpretable*. When agreement takes place, the result is that two (or more) syntactic elements or positions share the same feature that Agree acted upon. An important implication of Agree is that it creates non-local syntactic relations (Chomsky 2000, 2001).

In order to apply the agreement mechanism, there is a need to first propose a syntactic structure for AwF. I will use the in-situ object focus in (35) as a template.

proposed in the next section. However, Aremu (2025) argues against such a QR-approach with strong evidence. See Aremu (2025) for an extended discussion.

- (35) Adam go [chworō]_F *yerane* mo.
 Adam kill.PFV fowl only FOC
 ‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’

As indicated earlier, I assume that while the adnominal-*yerane* projects a **Particle Phrase (PrtP)** above the focus associate, but below *moP*, the exclusive Op_{only} heads an **Exclusive Phrase (ExclP)** that is merged between the CP/TP and the vP Figure 5. In Figure 5, the Prt head is specified with a valued uninterpretable exclusive feature [*uExcl*:2]. The Excl head (Op_{only}) on the other hand, has an unvalued interpretable exclusive feature [*iExcl*:_]. The idea is that the exclusive interpretation comes from the null Op_{only} . The agreement is on the basis of feature valuation. Thus, it is the unvalued feature on Excl that serves as the probe. It probes downward for a suitable goal and finds the valued Prt head. The latter then values the exclusive feature on the Excl head.

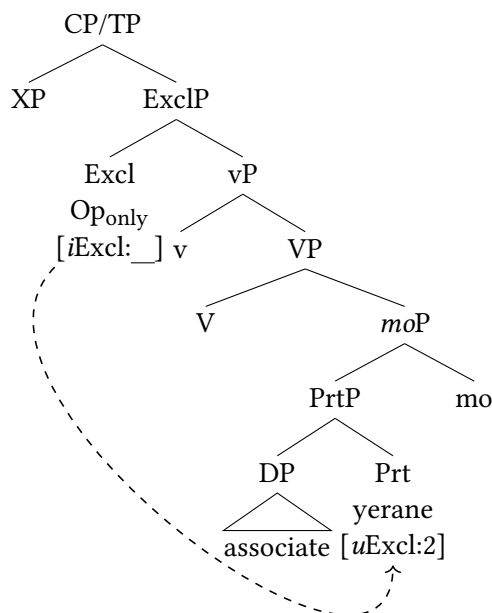


Figure 5: Agreement of Op_{only} and *yerane*

The tree in Figure 5 shows when the probe searches for the goal, and Figure 6 shows when the value has been copied to the probe in the form of [2]. The agree-

ment mechanism here maintains a downward Agree as in the focus derivation.²¹ Similarly, feature valuation serves as the probe.

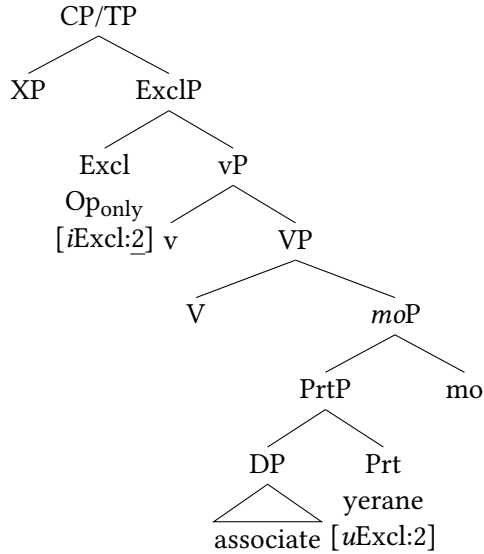


Figure 6: AwF structure after feature valuation

The tree in Figure 7 shows what a full TP structure with an association with direct object focus looks like.

4.3 Extending to other Mabilia languages

Although this study situates Kasem in a pool of other studies that have adopted the bipartite analysis, it is the first of its kind among the Mabilia languages as far as I know. The prediction is that the analysis that is proposed here for Kasem may be extended to the other Mabilia languages. For example, Kusaal, another Mabilia language, behaves similarly to Kasem with regard to the behaviour of ‘only’. In Kusaal, the adnominal-‘only’ is *ma’aa*. It always follows the focus associate whether in an in-situ position (36a) or in an ex-situ position (36b).²² The only difference is that while the in-situ focus marker follows the focus associate

²¹Unlike a few of the previous studies (cf. Sun 2021, Yip 2025: a.o.), here there is no movement of the adnominal-*yerane* to Spec,ExclP for Spec-head agreement, or an upward Agree between *yerane* and Op_{only} .

²²In Kusaal, the in-situ focus marker is *ne*, while the ex-situ focus marker is *ka*, as seen in the examples.

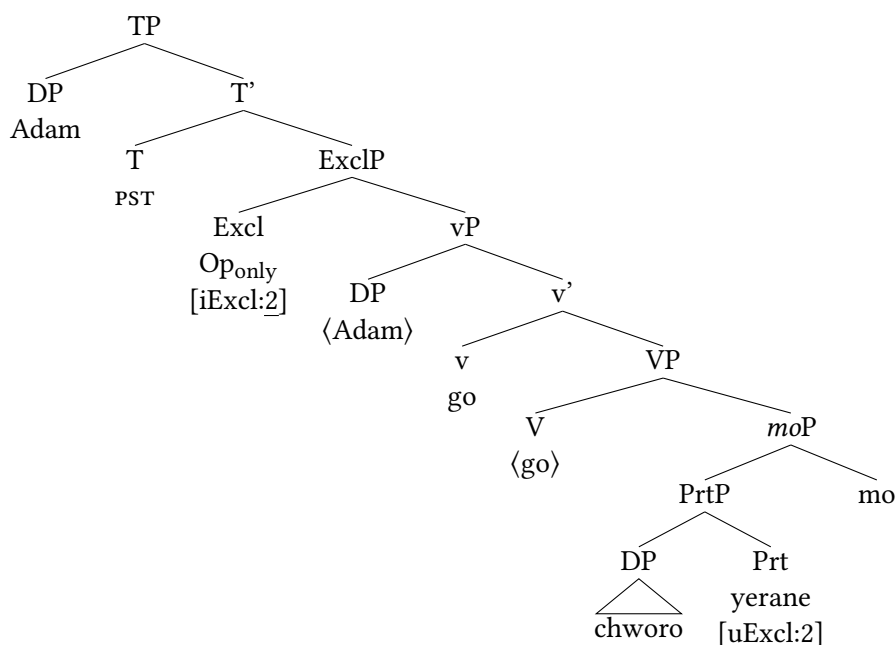


Figure 7: Full AwF structure

and the exclusive particle in Kasem, the in-situ focus marker precedes the focus associate and the exclusive particle in Kusaal (36a). I do not think that this constitutes any problem for the bipartite analysis that I assume in this paper. So, I propose that the same analysis can be extended to Kusaal, and other Mabilia languages as well.²³ I leave this for a future study.

- (36) a. Adam kɔdig nɛ [nua]_F ma'aa.
 Adam kill.PFV FOC fowl only
 'Adam slaughtered only A FOWL.'
- b. [Nua]_F ma'aa ka Adam kɔdig.
 fowl only FOC Adam kill
 'Adam slaughtered only A FOWL.'

²³See Abubakari (2018, 2019) for some descriptions of the Kusaal focus system and association with focus.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, I have described the syntactic property of the exclusive focus sensitive particle *yerane* in relation with narrow focus. As a way of setting the stage for the discussion on association with focus, I first described the focus marking strategies in Kasem, and went further to propose a syntactic analysis for focus in the language. I argued that the contiguous nature of the focus marker *mo* in the language allows for a constituent analysis with the focus DP. In other words, the focus marker forms a complex constituent with the focalized element. Having done this, I introduced the data on the exclusive particle *yerane* and argued that it has an *adnominal*-only syntactic positioning. This is in contrast to the *adverbial*-only analysis that has been proposed for *nur* in German, for example (Jacobs 1983, Büring & Hartmann 2001, Mursell 2021). I argue that we can maintain the EVP proposal only by assuming that *yerane* is an ad-focal particle which is licensed by a high covert exclusive Op_{only} . This leads us to a bipartite analysis which means that there is a high exclusive Op which heads an $ExclP$ and is responsible for the exclusive interpretation. *Yerane* on the other hand is a semantically inert functional head of $PrtP$.²⁴ Evidence for such a claim comes from the ability of the *adnominal*-only to trigger an ambiguous reading in the presence of modals and higher predicates. Thus, in order to link the Op_{only} to *yerane*, I assume an Agree system which requires the latter (which is uninterpretable but valued) to value the former (which is interpretable but unvalued). At the end, I predicted the possibility of extending the analysis that was developed for Kasem to the other Mabilia languages. Finally, this study provides cross-linguistic support (from a West African language) for the bipartite approach to the syntax of *only*.

Abbreviations

AwF	association with focus	N	noun
DEF	definite	IMM	immediate
DET	determiner	IPFV	imperfective
DISJ	disjunct	NEG	negation, negative
EPP	extended projection	PFV	perfective
	principle	PL	plural
EXCL	exclusive	PLA	principle of lexical
FOC	focus		association

²⁴Whether the adfocal particle is indeed semantically inert is a topic for a future research. But, for now, I leave it as such.

PRT	particle	SG	singular
PST	past	TOP	topic
Q	question particle	3	third person
QP	quantifier phrase		

Acknowledgements

First, I want to thank my language consultants: Mr. Fedelix Addah and Mr. Emmanuel Ayiredaga Apebuga for sharing their language with me. I am grateful to Katharina Hartmann, Johannes Mursell, Anke Himmelreich, and Samuel Acheampong for discussions of various parts of this paper. I also appreciate the two reviewers and the editors for their helpful comments and suggestions. Lastly, but not the least, I want to say a big thank you to the audience of ACAL54, Connecticut, for their great comments. This research is funded by the DFG-funded project on the “VP-periphery of the Mabilia languages” (PI: Katharina Hartmann).

References

- Abubakari, Hasiyatu. 2018. *Aspects of Kusaal grammar: The syntax-information structure interface*. Wien: Universität Wien. (Doctoral dissertation).
- Abubakari, Hasiyatu. 2019. Contrastive focus particles in Kusaal. In Emily Clem, Peter Jenks & Hannah Sande (eds.), *Theory and description in African linguistics: Selected papers from the 47th Annual Conference on African Linguistics*, 325–347. Berlin: Language Science Press.
- Aremu, Daniel. 2025. Towards a propositional concord approach for exclusives in Kasem. In Shweta Akolkar, Amber Galvano, Akil Ismael, Kang Franco Liu & Line Mikkelsen (eds.), *Proceedings of the 42nd West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 42)*, 36–45. Somerville, MA: Cascadia Proceedings Project.
- Awedoba, Albert K. 1996. Kasem nominal genders and names. *Institute of African Studies Research Review* 12(1). 8–24.
- Barbiers, Sjef. 2010. Focus particle doubling. In C. Jan-Wouter Zwart & Mark de Vries (eds.), *Structure preserved: Studies in syntax for Jan Koster*, 21–30. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Barbiers, Sjef. 2014. Syntactic doubling and deletion as a source of variation. In M. Carme Piccolo (ed.), *Linguistic variation in the minimalist framework*, 197–223. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Bayer, Josef. 1996. *Directionality and logical form: On the scope of focusing particles and Wh-in situ*. Dordrecht: Kluwer.

- Bayer, Josef. 1999. Bound focus in German or how can association with focus be achieved without going semantically astray? In Georges Rebuschi & Laurice Tuller (eds.), *The grammar of focus*, 55–82. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Bayer, Josef. 2018. Criterial freezing in the syntax of particles. In Jutta Hartmann, Marion Jäger, Andreas Konietzko, Susanne Winkler & Andreas Kehl (eds.), *Freezing: Theoretical approaches and empirical domains*, 225–263. Berlin: De Gruyter Mouton.
- Beaver, David I & Brady Z Clark. 2008. *Sense and sensitivity: How focus determines meaning*. London: Wiley-Blackwell.
- Bianchi, Valentina, Giuliano Bocci & Silvio Cruschina. 2016. Focus fronting, unexpectedness, and evaluative implicatures. *Semantics and Pragmatics* 9(3). 1–54.
- Bodomo, Adams. 2020. Mabilia: Its etymological genesis, geographical spread, and some salient genetic features. In Adams Bodomo, H. Abubakari & Samuel A. Issah (eds.), *Handbook of the Mabilia languages of West Africa*, 5–34. Gliencke: Galda Verlag.
- Branan, Kenyon & Michael Yoshitaka Erlewine. 2023. Anti-pied-piping. *Language* 99(3). 603–653.
- Büring, Daniel & Katharina Hartmann. 2001. The syntax and semantics of focus-sensitive particles in German. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 19. 229–281.
- Carstens, Vicki & Jochen Zeller. 2020. ‘only’ in Nguni: A phrase-final particle meets antisymmetry theory. *Linguistic Inquiry* 51(2). 199–235.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2000. Minimalist inquiries: The framework. In Roger Martin, David Michaels & Juan Uriagereka (eds.), *Step by step: Essays on Minimalist syntax in honor of Howard Lasnik*, 89–155. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2001. Derivation by phase. In Michael Kenstowicz (ed.), *Ken Hale: A life in language*, vol. 482, 1–52. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Cruschina, Silvio. 2009. The syntactic role of discourse-related features. *Cambridge Occasional Papers in Linguistics* 5. 15–30.
- Cruschina, Silvio. 2012. *Discourse-related features and functional projections*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- É. Kiss, Katalin. 1998. Identificational focus versus information focus. *Language* 74(2). 245–273.
- Erlewine, Michael Yoshitaka. 2014a. Explaining leftward focus association with “even” but not “only”. In *Proceedings of sinn und Bedeutung*, vol. 18, 128–145.
- Erlewine, Michael Yoshitaka. 2014b. *Movement out of focus*. MIT. (Doctoral dissertation).

- Erlewine, Michael Yoshitaka & Hadas Kotek. 2018. Focus association by movement: Evidence from Tanglewood. *Linguistic Inquiry* 49(3). 441–463.
- Grubic, Mira. 2015. *Focus and alternative sensitivity in Ngamo (West-Chadic)*. University of Potsdam. (Doctoral dissertation).
- Hartmann, Katharina & Malte Zimmermann. 2008. Not only ‘only’, but ‘too’, too: Alternative-sensitive particles in Bura. In Atle Grønn (ed.), *Proceedings of SuB 12*, 196–211.
- Hole, Daniel. 2015. A distributed syntax for evaluative ‘only’ sentences. *Zeitschrift für Sprachwissenschaft* 34(1). 43–77.
- Hole, Daniel. 2017. A crosslinguistic syntax of scalar and non-scalar focus particle sentences: The view from Vietnamese and Chinese. *Journal of East Asian Linguistics* 26. 389–409.
- Iatridou, Sabine & Sergei Tatevosov. 2016. Our even. *Linguistics and philosophy* 39. 295–331.
- Jacobs, Joachim. 1983. *Fokus und skalen*. Tübingen: Niemeyer.
- Jacobs, Joachim. 1986. The syntax of focus and adverbials in German. In Werner Abraham & Sjaak de Meij (eds.), *Topic, focus, and configurationality*, 103–128. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Kayne, Richard S. 1998. Overt vs. Covert movements. *Syntax* 1. 128–191.
- König, Ekkehard. 1991. *The meaning of focus particles: A comparative perspective*. London: Routledge.
- Lee, Youngjoo. 2004. *The syntax and semantics of focus particles*. Massachusetts Institute of Technology. (Doctoral dissertation).
- Meyer, Marie-Christine & Uli Sauerland. 2009. A pragmatic constraint on ambiguity detection. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 27. 139–150.
- Mursell, Johannes. 2021. *The syntax of information-structural agreement*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Penka, Doris. 2011. *Negative indefinites* (Oxford Studies in Linguistics). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Pesetsky, David & Esther Torrego. 2007. The syntax of valuation and the interpretability of features. In Simin Karimi, Vida Samiian & Wendy Wilkins (eds.), *Phrasal and clausal architecture: Syntactic derivation and interpretation*, 262–294. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Quek, Yihui & Aron Hirsch. 2017. Severing focus form and meaning in Standard and colloquial Singapore English. In Andrew Lamont & Katerina Tetzloff (eds.), *Proceedings of NELS 47*.
- Reis, Marga. 2005. On the syntax of So-called focus particles in German: A reply to Büring and Hartmann 2001. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 23. 459–483.

- Rooth, Mats E. 1985. *Association with focus (Montague grammar, semantics, only, even)*. Amherst: University of Massachusetts.
- Rooth, Mats E. 1992. A theory of focus interpretation. *Natural language semantics* 1. 75–116.
- Smeets, Liz & Michael Wagner. 2018. Reconstructing the syntax of focus operators. *Semantics and Pragmatics* 11. 6:1–6:30. DOI: 10.3765/sp.11.6.
- Sun, Yenan. 2021. A bipartite analysis of *zhiyou* ‘only’ in Mandarin Chinese. *Journal of East Asian Linguistics* 30. 319–355.
- Taglicht, Joseph. 1984. *Message and emphasis: On focus and scope in English*. London: Longman.
- Yip, Ka-Fai. 2025. Agreeing with ‘only’. In Nikolas Webster, Yağmur Kiper, Richard Wang & Sichen Larry Lyu (eds.), *Proceedings of the 41st West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 42)*, 616–626. Somerville, MA: Cascadia Proceedings Project.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2004. *Sentential negation and negative concord*. University of Amsterdam. (Doctoral dissertation).
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2008. *Negative concord is syntactic agreement*. Manuscript, University of Amsterdam.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2011. On the syntactically complex status of negative indefinites. *Journal of Comparative Germanic Syntax* 14. 111–138.